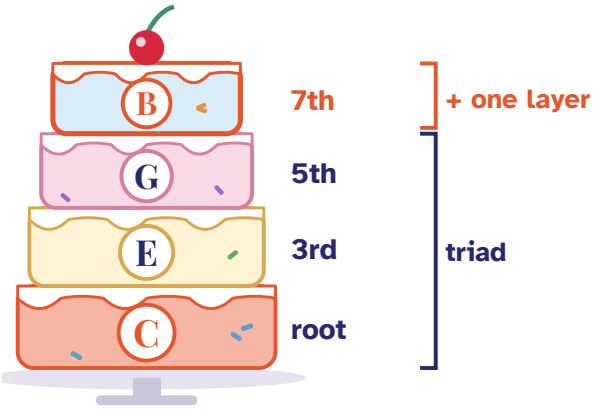
PART V · CHORDS · 5

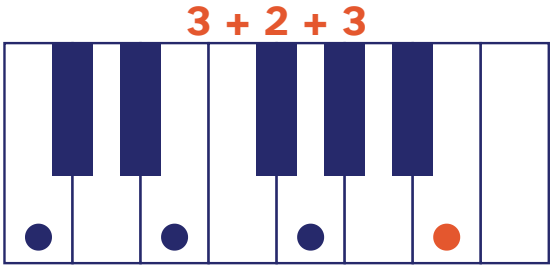
Seventh chords

Three notes make a plain chord. Add one more note on top and it can sound dreamy, bluesy or spooky. The new note is the **7th**.

THE SECRET
One more layer on the cake and the chord changes colour.

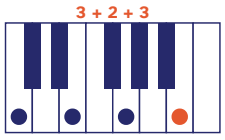


1. Build the triad: **C E G**.
2. Skip one, add the next: **B**.
3. Count the keys between: **3 + 2 + 3**. That is **Cmaj7**.



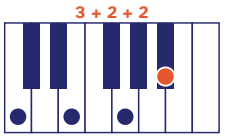
Five flavours, all on C

Cmaj7



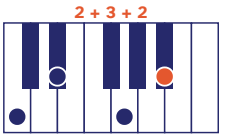
C E G B
dreamy
bossa nova, film

C7



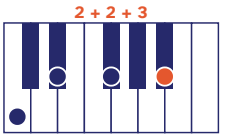
C E G B♭
bluesy
the blues

Cm7



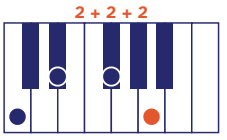
C E♭ G B♭
mellow
soul, jazz ballads

Cø7



C E♭ G♭ B♭
searching
jazz, film noir
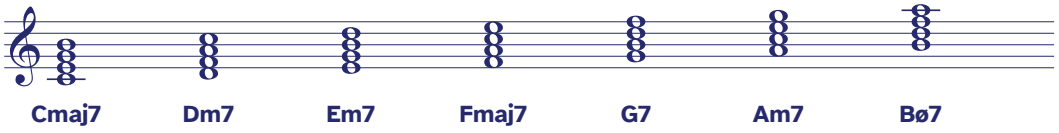
C°7



C E♭ G♭ B𝄫
spooky
old film villains

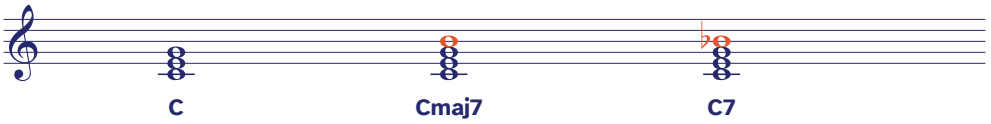
How the names work: major triad + major 7th = **maj7** · major triad + minor 7th = **7**, the **dominant 7th** (C7 is said “C seven” or “C dominant seventh”: in a key it sits on the 5th note, the dominant, as V7) · minor triad + minor 7th = **m7** · diminished triad + minor 7th = **ø7** · diminished triad + diminished 7th = **°7**.

A seventh on every note of C major



Only white keys: count the keys between to name each one.

PART V · CHORDS · 5 · CONTINUED

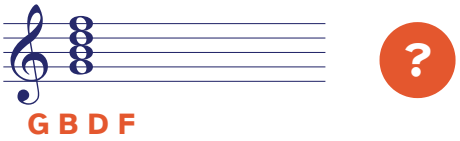


One note decides: B makes Cmaj7, B♭ makes C7. Everything below stays the same.

Spot the difference

EXAMPLE 1

Which seventh is it? G B D F



1. **Count the keys between** each layer: G to B, B to D, D to F.
2. **Which of the five flavours** has those three numbers?
3. **The root is G.** Name the chord.

3 + 2 + 2, the bluesy one, on G: **G7**.

GAME

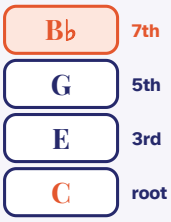
Which seventh?

1	2	3
F A C E	C E G B♭	D F A C

A cake with one more layer. Name each chord.

Answer: 1 Fmaj7 · 2 C7 · 3 Dm7.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Play C7, then Cmaj7.

C E G B♭, then C E G B. One key changes the top layer: bluesy, then dreamy.

PART V · CHORDS · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Cmaj7 or C7: which note changes?

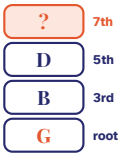


1. **Both start with C major:** C E G.
2. **Compare the top layers.** Which one note is different?
3. **Count the keys between** G and the top layer in each.

Only the top layer changes: **B** (3 between) is Cmaj7, **B♭** (2 between) is C7.

EXAMPLE 3

Build G7

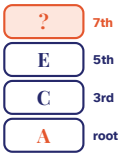


1. **Build G major:** G B D.
2. **Skip one more letter** above D: which?
3. **Count the keys between** D and it: 2 (the bluesy 7) or 3 (maj7)?

G B D **F**: 3 + 2 + 2, so it is **G7**.

EXAMPLE 4

Build Am7



1. **Build A minor:** A C E (2 + 3).
2. **Add the next letter** but one above E.
3. **Count the keys between** E and the new layer.

A C E **G**: 2 + 3 + 2, so it is **Am7**.

TRAP

- × Writing C7 when you mean Cmaj7: "7" alone means the bluesy one, with B♭.
- × Stacking the 7th from the wrong note: count a 7th up from the root, not from the 5th.

SEE ALSO
Four kinds of triad p. 113 · Chords in a key p. 116

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 9–10 · Online: Library › Chords